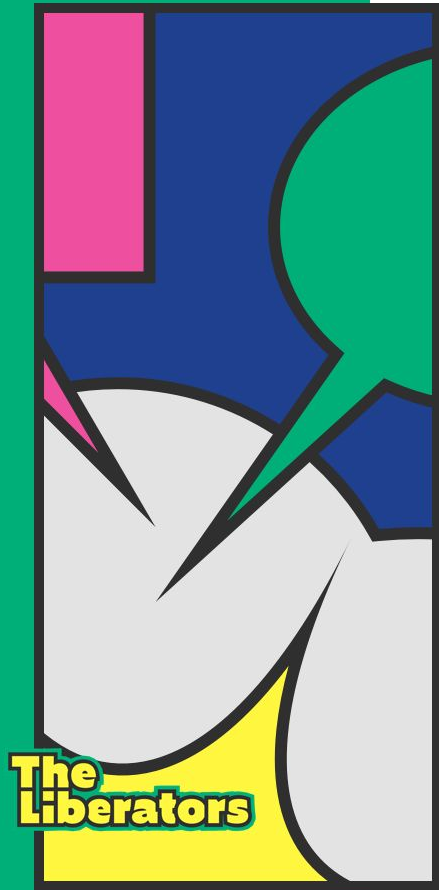
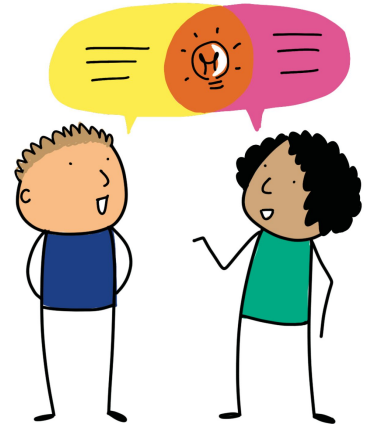




Liberating Structures: Troika Consulting

A collection of practical tips, tweaks, and resources



Liberating Structures were developed by Henri Lipmanowicz and Keith McCandless. The foundational Liberating Structures materials are shared under a Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 license (CC BY-SA 4.0).

These Practice Guides build on their work and combine it with our own experiences, illustrations, and practical tips.



Introduction

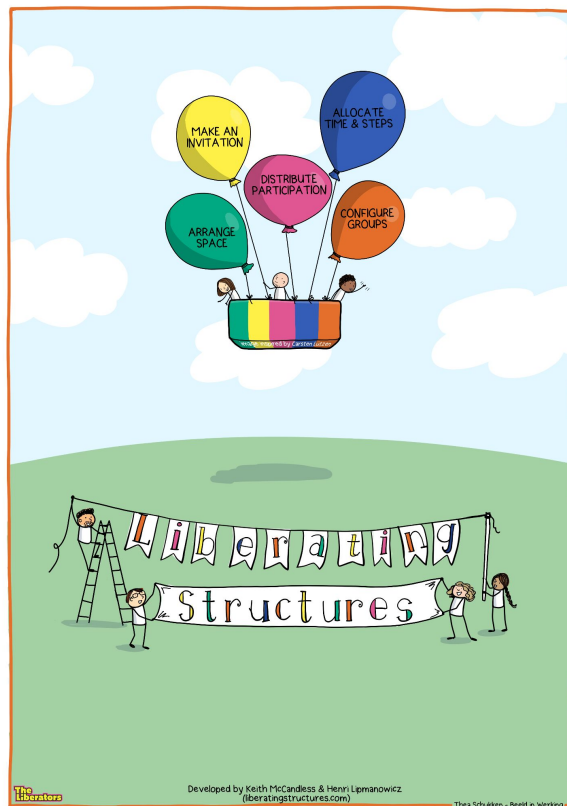
For almost a decade, Liberating Structures have been an important part of my facilitation toolkit. Over the years, I've created my own materials, enjoyed using those created by others, picked up countless practical tips, and discovered many useful tweaks.

Until now, all of these were scattered across different places, often leaving me searching for that one illustration, idea, or tip when I needed it most. So I decided to bring everything together in one place, with a separate guide for each Liberating Structure. And yes, it definitely satisfies my inner facilitation nerd. 🤖

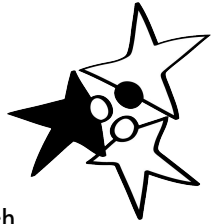
I'm creating these guides mostly for myself, and they'll probably never be finished. I keep learning, experimenting, and discovering new things. But since sharing freely with the community is an important part of what we do, I'll also make them available through [our public GitHub repository](#).

I hope you'll find something useful in them too. Enjoy!

[Barry Overeem](#)



About Troika Consulting



Troika Consulting is a Liberating Structure that helps people get practical and imaginative help from each other. In about 30 minutes, everyone has the opportunity to bring a challenge they are facing and receive advice from two others.

Participants work in groups of three, taking turns as the “client” and “consultants.” The client briefly shares their challenge and the kind of help they need. After asking clarifying questions, the consultants discuss possible ideas, suggestions, and perspectives while the client turns around and simply listens. The client then turns back and shares what they found most valuable before the roles switch.

Having the client turn around may feel unusual at first, but it is an important part of the structure. It prevents the client from immediately responding to, explaining, or dismissing suggestions. Instead, they can focus entirely on listening and noticing what resonates. At the same time, the consultants are encouraged to explore the challenge together rather than directing their advice at the client.

Troika Consulting taps into the experience and wisdom already present in a group. Instead of relying on a manager, coach, or expert whenever a challenge comes up, people discover how much help they can offer each other. It makes asking for and offering help a shared responsibility. Used regularly, Troika Consulting can strengthen relationships, spread knowledge across a group, and build greater capacity for self-organization.

Illustration we created
with [Thea Schukken](#)



Troika Consulting

Get Practical And Imaginative Help
From Colleagues Immediately



*What is your challenge?
What next steps do you have in mind?
What kind of help do you need?*



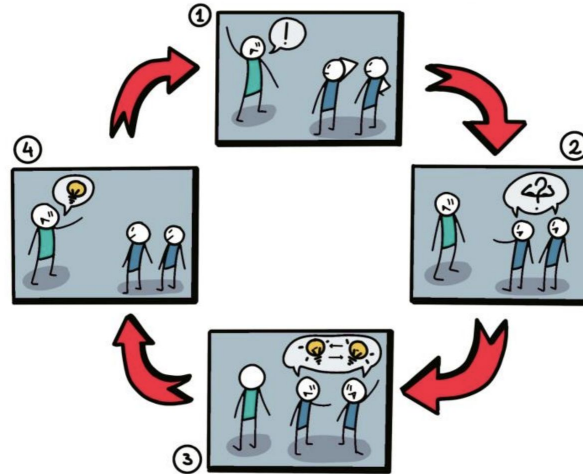
- 1 Share the invitation, and give everyone time to reflect individually.
- 2 Form trios. One participant, the “client,” shares their challenge. (1-2 min.)
- 3 The other two participants, the “consultants,” ask clarifying questions. They do not judge or offer solutions. (1-2 min.)
- 4 The client turns away and listens silently while the consultants discuss their ideas. (4-5 min.)
- 5 The client turns back around and shares what they found most valuable. (1-2 min.)
- 6 The group repeats these steps so each person gets to be a client.

 Developed by Keith McCandless & Henri Lipmanowicz
(liberatingstructures.com)

Thea Schukken - Beeld in Werking

TROIKA

Consulting



GET PRACTICAL AND IMAGINATIVE HELP FROM
COLLEAGUES IMMEDIATELY

LINDA VAN SINTEN

Illustration by
[Linda van Sinten](#)

Troika Consulting
in action



**Tips, tweaks,
and thoughts**

- Give each small group enough space. Spread groups out so they can focus on their own conversation without being distracted by nearby groups.
 - Remind the consultants to talk with each other, not to the client. During this part, the client simply listens and does not answer questions, clarify, defend, or comment on what is being said.
 - Encourage clients to simply listen and notice what stands out or feels useful. Offering pen and paper can help them capture ideas.
 - Increase self-organization with each round. Explain the process in detail for round one. In round two, only support the timeboxing. For round three, consider simply giving them 10 minutes and letting them organize everything else themselves.
- 



Tips, tweaks, and thoughts

- Invite participants to form diverse groups. Mixing roles, functions, backgrounds, and perspectives can bring unexpected ideas and prevent people from approaching the challenge through the same lens.
 - Have a plan for uneven groups. If you end up with a group of four, you have a few options: add an extra consultant, invite someone to observe as a Simple Ethnographer, or promote someone to co-facilitator!
 - As a client, don't turn back too quickly. A brief silence between the consultants doesn't mean they're finished. Resist the temptation to turn around or jump back into the conversation. Give them space to think and continue when they're ready.
 - As consultants, use the full timebox. If you feel you've already given enough advice after two minutes, think harder. Explore another angle, question your assumptions, or build on each other's ideas.
- 



Tips, tweaks, and thoughts

- Encourage consultants to go beyond the obvious. Offer different perspectives, unusual ideas, or suggestions the client may not have considered yet.
 - If the first round does not generate enough useful insights, try a second round with the same consultants. Invite the client to briefly share what they found useful so far and what they would like more help with. Then have them turn around again for another round. Two short, focused rounds can be more effective than one long consultation.
 - Encourage clients to notice their own reactions while listening. What surprises them? What resonates? What makes them uncomfortable? These reactions can offer useful insights too.
 - Be strict when clients break the rules. If they turn around, interrupt, or join the consultants' conversation, remind them to simply listen. By getting involved, they're likely to get less value from the consultation.
- 



Online tips & tweaks

- Give participants a few minutes in their breakout room before starting. Let them introduce themselves and get settled before beginning the consultation.
 - Explain the full process before opening the breakout rooms. You won't be there to introduce each step as it happens.
 - Make the instructions easily accessible. Share them in the chat so participants can refer back to them during the exercise.
 - Let groups manage their own time. Make clear that they are responsible for moving through the three rounds themselves. Assigning someone to keep an eye on time can help.
 - Keep your camera on when you're the client. Stay as close as possible to the in-person experience: physically turn your chair around so your back faces the screen. This helps you resist reacting to the consultants while remaining visibly present.
 - Avoid interrupting breakout rooms with too many facilitator messages. If you send reminders, limit them to useful milestones.
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Interested in learning more?

Articles about Troika Consulting:

- [Our thoughts](#) on this Liberating Structure
- [How to use Troika Consulting online?](#)
- [The official description](#) of Troika Consulting

Looking for (even) more inspiration?

- Check the resources on [the Liberating Structures website](#)
- Check [our blog](#) with 100+ articles
- Browse our public [GitHub repository](#) with illustrations, DIY workshops, templates, papers, and other free resources.
- Here's the [webshop](#) with Linda van Sinten's illustrations
- Join our public [online or in-person meetups](#)

Interested in collaborating?

- Check [my workshop offerings](#).
- I'm available as a trainer or facilitator for meetings, workshops, and other gatherings.
- Whether you want to learn Liberating Structures or use them to tackle a real challenge, I'd be happy to help.

Get in touch: barry.overeem@theliberators.com



A stylized graphic featuring a rainbow with orange, pink, and white bands, set against a blue background. The rainbow is curved and appears to be part of a larger, abstract design. The center of the image is a bright yellow area.

The Liberators

Unleashing Organisational Superpowers